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Transcripción de audio

IELTS Academic · Set 5

01 Comprensión auditiva - Sección 1: Reserva de un recorrido guiado por la ciudad

Agent: Good afternoon, Heritage City Walks. How can I help you?

Customer: Hello, I'd like to book a guided walking tour of the old town for this weekend.

Agent: Of course. Could I take your name?

Customer: Yes, it's Rachel Hastings.

Agent: Could you spell your surname for me?

Customer: Certainly - it's H-A-S-T-I-N-G-S.

Agent: Thank you, Ms Hastings. And a phone number in case we need to reach you?

Customer: It's 07924 665130.

Agent: Lovely. Can I ask how you heard about our tours?

Customer: A friend recommended you, actually. She did the tour last month.

Agent: Before we compare the two routes, may I check whether anyone in your party has limited mobility? Most of the old town is accessible, but one narrow lane has several uneven steps, so the leader can use a parallel street when necessary.

Customer: No one needs a step-free route, although my mother prefers a steady pace.

Agent: That will be fine. The leader pauses regularly to explain the buildings, so it never feels like a continuous hike.

Agent: That's great to hear. Now, we run two walks. Would you prefer the evening tour or the morning one?

Customer: I was thinking about the evening walk at first, but I'll go for the morning tour - I'd rather see everything in daylight.

Agent: Perfect, the morning tour it is. It begins outside the cathedral, on the main square.

Customer: Outside the cathedral. Got it. Is there anything I should bring?

Agent: Mainly just make sure you wear comfortable shoes, as there's a fair amount of walking on cobbled streets.

Customer: What happens if the weather turns bad? The forecast looks changeable.

Agent: We only cancel for severe conditions. Light rain is not usually a problem because part of the route passes through covered arcades. If we cancel, you can move the booking to another date or receive a refund. Groups are kept fairly small as well, so people can hear the commentary without crowding the pavement.

Customer: Good. I was hoping it would be informative rather than rushed.

Customer: No problem. What will we actually see?

Agent: The guide takes you through the medieval quarter and points out the old market, which dates back six hundred years. Around midday, the group stops for lunch at a café by the river.

Agent: You may take photographs, but please stay with the group at road crossings. The leader cannot hold up the whole route if one guest falls far behind.

Customer: That is fair. Is there a place to sit during the walk?

Agent: There are brief stops in two quiet courtyards. They are useful for anyone who needs a rest, and they give the leader time to answer questions.

Customer: That sounds wonderful. Could you tell me a bit more about the options and prices?

Agent: Certainly. The morning tour lasts three hours and covers about four kilometres. It costs twenty-five pounds per person, and that includes a printed guidebook to take home.

Customer: I like having some background before I visit a place. Will the commentary assume that everyone already knows the city's history?

Agent: Not at all. The leader introduces each period in plain language and explains how the streets changed over time. There is enough detail for people who are genuinely interested, but unfamiliar names are never presented as a list to memorise. Guests can ask questions at the longer stopping points, and the leader will distinguish a documented event from a local story.

Customer: That sounds much more engaging than simply following a route on my phone.

Agent: That is what we aim for. We also ask guests to keep conversations quiet while an explanation is in progress, so everyone in the group can follow it.

Customer: And if I wanted something longer?

Agent: There's also a full-day tour. That one runs for six hours and covers nine kilometres, priced at forty pounds. Best of all, a two-course lunch is included in that package.

Customer: Excellent. I'll take the morning tour for now.

Agent: Wonderful. I'll book you straight in.

02 Comprensión auditiva - Sección 2: Charla de inducción para voluntarios

Good morning everyone, and thank you for coming to the induction day at Rivermead Nature Reserve. I'm Tom, the volunteer coordinator, and I'll explain what volunteering here involves. Let me start with the work itself. Over the summer, there's a great deal to do. Now, some of you imagine you'll spend your time guiding visitors around the site, but that's actually handled by our trained staff. What volunteers will really help with is planting trees along the new woodland trail, and counting birds for our annual wildlife survey. The fences are repaired by outside contractors, and the café is run by paid staff, so those aren't jobs for volunteers. We organise the rota several weeks ahead, but you are not expected to attend every session.

When you offer to help on a particular day, please arrive promptly and sign in before joining your team. This lets us account for everybody if an area has to close unexpectedly. New volunteers normally work beside someone experienced until they are familiar with the routine. Now for some practical points. To join the main programme, you must be at least eighteen years old - there's a separate scheme for younger helpers. Today's induction is quite relaxed, and it lasts about two hours, including a short tour of the grounds. Please remember that this is a protected site rather than an ordinary public park. Keep to the marked routes, avoid disturbing nesting areas and never handle an animal unless a staff member has asked you to do so. If you are uncertain about a task, pause and ask.

We value careful observation much more than completing a job quickly. For outdoor work, please wear sturdy boots. Trainers aren't suitable, because the paths get very muddy after rain. When you arrive, you can leave your things safely, as lockers are provided for your personal belongings - there's no need to carry a bag around the site. You'll also be pleased to hear that free hot drinks are available in the staff room all day. Most sessions begin with a short briefing at the main office. The team leader will explain the aim for the day, show you the area on a site map and check that each pair has the right tools. At the end, return all shared items and sign out, even if another team is still working. Please tell us in advance about any health issue that could affect outdoor work.

We can often adapt a role, but we need enough notice to do so safely. You are also welcome to ask why a task is needed; understanding the purpose tends to produce more careful work. Safety comes first here. If you have an accident of any kind, however minor, you must report any injuries to the supervisor on duty immediately - please don't wait until you get home. The reserve keeps a record of what each team completes, but the purpose is to understand the condition of the site rather than to rank individuals by speed. Write down anything unexpected, including a task that could not be finished because the ground was unsuitable or an area was occupied by wildlife. A precise note is more useful than an optimistic guess.

Please clean shared equipment before returning it, report damage instead of hiding it, and leave each work area as you found it. These habits allow the next team to begin safely and give staff reliable information when they plan later sessions. Questions are encouraged during the closing discussion, especially if an instruction seemed different in practice from the way it sounded indoors. To keep everyone informed, you'll receive a monthly newsletter by email, listing upcoming events

and work parties. Do read it, because that's how we announce any last-minute changes. Throughout each task, work at a pace that allows you to notice your surroundings. If conditions change or a boundary is unclear, stop the activity and contact the team leader.

Responsible decisions in the field are part of the contribution, not a failure to complete the planned list. Finally, we like to say thank you properly. The end-of-year celebration is held in December, with food and music for all our volunteers and their families. It's always a wonderful evening, and I very much hope you'll come along. Right - let's start that tour of the reserve.

03 Comprensión auditiva - Sección 3: Conversación para planificar una salida de campo

Tutor: Right, Meg and Ryan, let's plan your ecology field trip. I've suggested the Fenwick Estuary. Any thoughts on why it's a good choice?

Meg: Well, it's quite close to the university, which is convenient.

Tutor: That's true, though honestly that wasn't my main reason. What really makes it ideal is the sheer variety of habitats - mudflats, salt marsh and woodland, all in one place.

Ryan: That does make it perfect for our module. And I read that a group went there two years ago.

Tutor: They did, but you'll be doing something quite different. Now, what will you focus your data collection on?

Meg: I thought we might survey the bird populations, since the estuary is famous for them.

Tutor: You could, but for this assignment I'd like you to concentrate on water quality - testing salinity and oxygen levels at different points.

Ryan: Should we take readings at random points, or use the same distance between sites?

Tutor: Use fixed intervals. Random sampling sounds attractive, but on a narrow estuary it could place most observations in one habitat by chance. Mark the positions on your map before you go, then take a preliminary reading at the first site to make sure the procedure is practical.

Meg: That should also make it easier to compare our results.

Meg: Do we all carry out every stage, or should we divide the work?

Tutor: Work in pairs and rotate roles after each site. One person should operate the meter while the other records the value and checks the location. Rotation reduces the risk that one person's technique creates a pattern in the data.

Ryan: And if a reading looks unusual?

Tutor: Repeat it once and keep both values. Do not silently replace an inconvenient result.

Ryan: Okay, water quality it is. How do we actually get out there?

Tutor: Good question. A coach would be far too expensive for a group your size, and the nearest train station is miles from the shore. So I've arranged a minibus, which the department will drive.

Meg: Great. The one thing I'm nervous about is the tides - I don't want us getting cut off on the mudflats.

Tutor: Very sensible. The weather should be fine that week, and the deadline isn't for a month, so those aren't concerns. But the tides are serious, so we'll check the timetable carefully.

Meg: How much detail should go in the final report?

Tutor: Enough for another group to follow your method. Explain where each site was, when the sample was taken and how the meter was used. Keep raw results separate from your comments.

Ryan: So we describe first and interpret later.

Tutor: Exactly. That will make your reasoning much easier to check.

Ryan: So what should we do first?

Tutor: Before anything else, please read the safety guidelines I've uploaded. Don't book the equipment or divide into teams until you've done that.

Ryan: Should we decide now what pattern we expect to see along the shore?

Tutor: You may write a prediction, but keep it separate from the observations. If you expect one direction of change, you can become less attentive to a result that points elsewhere.

Meg: Would a simple table help us keep those stages apart?

Tutor: Yes. Give the recorded values their own columns, then add brief field comments in a different space. When you return, plot the values before writing the explanation. The shape of the data may suggest a comparison you did not anticipate.

Ryan: And we should discuss an unusual point rather than delete it.

Tutor: Precisely. Check whether it reflects a recording error, a local condition or genuine variation, and state which explanation the evidence supports.

Meg: Understood. Anything to bring?

Tutor: Yes - a few essentials. Each of you must bring a waterproof jacket, as the shore is exposed. Remember to charge the camera the night before, so you can photograph your sites. Collect your water samples in labelled bottles, and record all your measurements in a notebook rather than on loose paper. And finally, submit the risk assessment to me by Friday.

Ryan: Will do. Thanks.

04 Comprensión auditiva - Sección 4: Apicultura urbana

Today I'd like to look at urban beekeeping - the practice of keeping honeybees within towns and cities, which has grown remarkably popular over the last decade. Let me start with some background. Contrary to what you might expect, cities can be surprisingly good places for bees. Because space at ground level is limited, hives are often placed on the rooftops of buildings - offices, schools and even hotels now host colonies high above the streets. Another advantage is temperature. Built-up areas tend to be a few degrees warmer than the surrounding countryside, and this extra warmth protects bees from frost during the colder months. An important distinction is that supporting honeybees is not automatically the same as supporting every urban pollinator.

Many solitary species use different nesting sites and travel over shorter distances. If too many managed colonies are concentrated in one district, competition for forage can increase. Good planning therefore begins with an estimate of what the surrounding habitat can sustain, rather than simply adding as many colonies as space allows. So what are the benefits? The most obvious one is pollination. As the bees forage, they dramatically improve the pollination of nearby gardens and parks, which means more flowers and better fruit crops. There's a culinary benefit too: because urban bees visit such a wide range of plants, city honey often has a distinctive flavour that many people prize.

And beyond the practical gains, keeping bees in visible places helps raise public awareness of wildlife and the threats it faces. Researchers also examine movement between managed and wild populations. A dense network of colonies may allow parasites to spread more easily, particularly when equipment is exchanged between keepers. Regular inspection and careful record-keeping make unusual changes easier to detect. The most successful projects combine colony health data with observations of plant diversity, seasonal conditions and the abundance of other insects. Of course, there are challenges. In some neighbourhoods, a lack of flowers means there simply isn't enough food to sustain large numbers of bees, and colonies can struggle. The bees may also be affected by pollution from traffic, which can settle on the plants they feed on. And a more human problem is that new keepers often lack proper training, which can lead to poorly managed hives and unhappy neighbours. There is also a question of scale. A single well-run hive can be a useful teaching tool, yet a rapid rise in hive numbers across a whole city may have effects that no one project can see. Long-term studies compare districts and seasons rather than relying on one successful year. They also distinguish between the amount of honey produced and the health of the wider insect community, since those measures do not always move in the same direction. So what would I advise anyone thinking of starting?

First, always register each hive with the local council, so that its location is on record. This is a legal requirement in many places. Second - and this is often forgotten - provide a nearby source of water. Bees need to drink, and without it they will visit your neighbours' swimming pools instead. For that reason, evaluation should begin before a new project is installed. Organisers can document the surrounding vegetation, note other insect species and agree how frequently colonies will be inspected. The same observations should continue afterwards, using a consistent method, so that change can be compared rather than remembered informally. Community projects are particularly

valuable when their records are shared with researchers, because a network of carefully monitored sites can reveal variation that one location cannot. Even then, interpretation must remain cautious: a difference between districts may reflect weather, land use or management practice. The aim is not to prove that every urban colony is beneficial or harmful, but to identify the conditions under which a project can coexist responsibly with the broader ecosystem. This approach also changes how success is communicated. A project should report setbacks and uncertainty alongside positive outcomes, and should revise its management when the observations justify doing so.

Transparent records allow residents, keepers and ecologists to discuss the same evidence instead of relying on enthusiasm alone. In the next lecture, we will look at how researchers track the health of these urban colonies. But for now, that is a good overview of the subject.